by SavantGuarde

# Chapter Thirty-Eight

• 4.38.1 • 4.38.2 •

## Bottoming Out

## 01

### CODY

In the long, dragging years after college, I thought that all I could ever want was to waste my life as efficiently as possible.

But I feel something different now as I sit in the foyer of a home I can barely afford, watching the first snow of the year lightly fall beyond the glass of my front window, sitting in a folding chair as I consider everything that brought me to this exact moment.

While my mind deliberates over whether I was actually going to kill myself — or just being pathetically dramatic — I still shiver from either the chill of the outside air or fear of the inevitable. Maybe my body refuses to forget what I almost did to it, even if my mind has moved on. I sit there for what feels like hours, entranced by the stillness of the outside world as the crystalline flakes glow like fireflies beneath the street lights. My phone is still in my hand: the group text written but still unsent, and I try to draw the energy to care just a little bit more.



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Some time after my meager patch of brown grass is covered in a layer of white, I hear a disturbance next door. Katiya's entry door screeches open at an improbable hour in the middle of the week, hanging open a little longer than it might take for a single person to get inside.

My eyes turn to the seven-segment neon numbers on the stove, reading a little after two o'clock in the morning: it's far too late for Katiya when she hates drinking.

With how early she gets up for patrol, she should be asleep by now.

So I grab my lacrosse stick again, scratched and battered to hell, and I stumble through the darkness towards the door as a strange wind flows out instead of in, and though I'm weaker than a peasant in Katiya's world, I decide I'll try for a bluff if I have to.

I slip through Katiya's door, rushing in with the sharp end of the stick leveled, ready to confront whatever faces me. But she doesn't have the energy to tackle me this time.

And it's not because I'm no longer a stranger.

Katiya stands at the entrance of her home. Nothing shines on her because she's dressed like a civilian, her hair disheveled and unbraided, and her skin sullied with dirt and grime. It looks as if she hesitates to enter her own home. I think up a joke to lighten her spirits, but quickly find it isn't the time.

"You never knocked," I say. "For a whole week or so. I don't think I ever even heard you: quiet as a seminary mouse."

"And neither did you," she says, and sniffles, though I'm unsure whether it's from the elements.

But it doesn't matter, because it's my chance to be warm for her, whether or not it's because I need it, too.

I rest my lacrosse stick against the wall with her greatsword, and swiftly approach her. She trembles, still hesitating to enter like a vampire without verbal permission, so I wrap my arms around her, goading her to join me on the IKEA couch we spent a weekend afternoon jamming into her world.



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She doesn't say anything, so I listen to her silence. I can feel the rise and fall of her chest as she tightens herself against me, wondering what catastrophe could ever bring the strong, resilient knight to her edge like this.

I look down at her head that's coated in leaves and branches, and as I rub her back, I feel that sensation of warmth slowly return to me, though it's not the power of her Essence, and as the minutes pass, waiting for her to turn her eyes to mine and explain the past week, I find my fingers working through her hair.

She snorts, halfway between a laugh and a sob. "What are you doing, Cody?"

"I thought you were training to be a knight, not a dryad," I say, gingerly tugging at a small branch snared between several strands of her golden hair.

She looks up at me with her amber eyes, reddened with tears, and I feel the cool air convect the places her sorrow saturated my shirt. I shiver, and realize I've been shivering this whole time, still paying for the consequences of my seditious sit-in against the will to live.

"Your hands are so cold," Katiya says. She leans back against the couch with a sniffle, taking my hand between hers, and is startled at how deathly pale my extremities are. "Khiras above, Cody, what happened?"

"I lost," I say. "And I almost lost it all."

"Lost what?" she asks, and I feel her radiant warmth spread across my pallid flesh with pins-and-needles.

"Lost my job. The respect of my father. And the will to live," I say, beginning to sob like Katiya as I struggle to mutter the last syllable. "I think I tried to kill myself."

She pauses, then pulls me closer. I expect her to ask where, and how, and why, but she just stays there, sitting in the same space of emotion that I do, refusing to leave when it's just the two of us leaning together, trading just enough heat to ward off the chill.

"I think I did, too," she says.



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"What happened?"

"I'm being released from the program."

"From being a Knight? But why?" I ask. "You do scouting every day now."

"It wasn't because of a mission I was assigned," she says. "It was because of a mission I chose."

"What mission?"

"I tried to save someone dear to me." She forms her mouth in the shape of a name, but hesitates to speak it, as if she doesn't deserve it. "I just got back from the funeral in my hometown. He was buried in the same place I killed him, and I just walked, and walked, until I begged the ground to swallow me the same way it made him disappear."

"I'm sorry," I say.

She pauses as if to let me explain myself, but my suffering has nothing to do with death. It's just genetic weakness.

She then asks, "and what happened to you?"

"It's pathetic," I preface.

"It's not pathetic if it makes you suffer," she says.

"I tried to solve a temporary problem with a permanent solution," I say. "I'm just so tired of being tired. I was only ever made to subsist, to never enjoy anything. And it just makes me jealous sometimes, you know. Of the ones that never lost that spark."

"Spark?" she says, and she rolls her eyes.

"That spark you have. You draw people to you because you feel through things so fully. I can tell you care so deeply. And it makes me feel so warm when I'm with you . . . even if we don't touch."

"It makes me weak," Katiya says. "It makes me defective as a Knight, as a protector."

"I think it's your greatest strength," I say, resting my trembling hand against her cheek. "Your world is in chaos, and yet you have the courage to really care, even if it asks so much more of you." I think of the passion of



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that kiss at the Renaissance Faire — how attracted I was to her strength and joy — and I don't have to read our sheet of rules again to remember the boundaries we set between us.

"But what do I do with that feeling, when all it ever does is drag me away from the fight? I tried to save . . . Bertram . . . and thought I was being brave, but I just ended up getting him killed," she says. "But what am I doing wrong?"

## 02

### KATIYA

"What am I doing wrong?" I repeat, and as all the past comes back to catch me, I feel my breaths shorten.

The trauma from my past has made me so combustible.

"All it ever feels like is I was made to burn," I say, feeling all those memories race my body with Essence, and if I don't slow my breathing, the life will leave my extremities. "I can't be calm — like Aryn, or you, and I just don't get it!"

The heat makes it hard for him to keep holding on, yet he doubles down, though I can feel it makes him wince. I try to breathe though the collapse is finally happening. It feels like everything folds inward as I finally break, though his embrace so desperately holds it all together.

"Just slow your breathing," he whispers in my ear, and it races my nerves. "You're still here. And you have no shortage of people that you can still protect."

"But I'll fall," I say.

"So I'll catch you," Cody whispers.

"But I'm out of the Guard," I tell him.



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"And yet winter is still coming," he says. "I lost my greatest source of pride, too. Winter layoffs for me are just as certain as that lake outside your window freezing over, and you know they'll need you. So don't write your purpose off yet."

I feel my strength slowly return. He kept me in place just long enough to reorder some of the pieces, and as he sweats from the heat, my body cools a little further.

"I just don't know how you do it. How you remain so cool," I say.

"I'm not that cool. I'm a nerd," he says.

It makes me laugh, and he looks relieved. "I mean, like, cool cool. Centered. Even when your world is falling apart, what keeps you together?"

"I don't know . . . it was a new thought I'd never had before. Maybe it's stupid . . . but, you know, I think I could only hear it at the absolute bottom," he says, and pauses so he can organize the words. "I couldn't feel anything. I had to reason with myself over why to go on, and it was a logical battle, and all I came to is, is that the only way to live is to show up." He thinks further, assembling words like screws. "The only way to succeed in being alive is just deciding to participate. For the next five seconds. Or the next five minutes. Or days, or getting out of bed, or deciding to go to the gym. Or taking a shot in the dark with some old dusty project, thinking it will get you closer to a dream."

The words give me pause. "But what about titles? You as an engineer, and me as a knight, and that's something we lost — something we have to fight for. To get back, to keep our honor, right? Doesn't it make you so afraid of everything you have to lose? You could die tomorrow, or get deathly ill, or the Chymaera could cross the lake tomorrow after a cold winter's night!"

"But now is all we have. I was at the bottom on that ledge, and I've been on other ledges before," Cody says, "whether it was a thought, or the absence of feeling. But I felt so centered there: as if the world was spinning around me for once, instead of trying to hold on to a world that tried to shake me off."



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It makes me think of the dreams beyond the cabin when I slept in Cody's bed: all of us, alive and dead, facing the sunrise with stillness though the mountain was still obscured by trees, hiding all the things we were afraid of, all the things that kept me sitting at the window since my innocence was taken.

"But we have to consider the past and future," I say. "We can't live in the present. That anxiety has to exist, because it saves us. Maybe we can take trips to scout that past and future when we have to."

"We just have to make our home here," Cody says, and now he sits on the couch with his arm around me. My head rests on his shoulder as we face my window where a light dusting of snow begins to fall, looking out into the darkness of the distant shore, no longer searching for amethyst in the veins of the trees.

"And I feel home when I'm with you," I hear myself say, and I want so badly to turn to him again, to not duck my head beneath his in avoidance, to show my feelings without pretense of a pretend victory. But I think it's something we should work towards, after we sort these things out.

I start to try to accept the past has happened. The future hasn't arrived. So I find a different way to channel those feelings.

"What will you do when you get it all back?" I ask.

"I'm not getting it all back," he says. "I think I'd just be getting a different version of it, but designing airfoils instead of batteries."

"No shit," I tell him. "I mean when the emptiness is gone."

"The emptiness never leaves," he says. "It just becomes less, I think, like a smaller part of the whole. Like when I had the project in school, when I was so busy and I never had the chance to be alone."

"Well, then what 'more' is going to make that 'less'?" I ask.

"More adventures," he says. "When I moved back here, on that drive home from California with my degree, I imagined all the stuff I'd do with grown-up money, like day trips going to the mountains or the city. Moe. Slice-of-life kind of stuff, like those TV shows I showed you where nothing really changes, but every episode is different."



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"Episodic," I say, remembering that derivative word.

"Yeah," Cody says. "And what about you?"

"I want to settle in somewhere where I won't be uprooted, for the first time in my life," I say. "To have adventures. Maybe some actual free time. To go to the hot springs in the mountains, or maybe see some of the world — maybe your world?"

"Sure," Cody says, and he yawns, withdrawing the phone from his pocket. His thumb swipes between pages of the square programs, settling on the messaging app, and after brief hesitation, he presses SEND on an unsent text. "I think that world would be worth it."

I look over his shoulder.

Cody Dunsmore // 02:57:I'm going to give it a shot. But I need your help.



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